

WiFi Applications

Though WiFi was originally developed for corporate LANs, it has garnered attention for two applications: hotspots and community access points. Hotspots are wireless access points deployed in high-traffic locations such as hotels, airports, and cafes. Typically, the facilities owner contracts with a company that installs the necessary equipment and Internet connection, with the revenue split between them. Sometimes the service provider keeps all the revenue, with the facilities owner benefiting from additional traffic the access point generates. End-users usually pay a per-minute or monthly access fee to connect to the Internet through the hotspot.

Over 4,000 hotspots have been deployed in the US, as well as in Europe and Asia. Most major hotel chains have announced plans to deploy WiFi hotspots, as have major US airports. The most prominent hotspot arrangement is MobileStar's deployment in Starbucks coffee houses around the country. MobileStar filed for bankruptcy, but its assets were purchased by VoiceStream and its hotspots are now supported under its T-Mobile brand. T-Mobile and Hewlett Packard recently announced that WiFi will be available in 2,000 Starbucks by the end of 2002. Community access points are similar to hotspots, but they are made freely available to anyone in the area. Typically, community access points are established by individuals or groups such as BAWUG in the San Francisco Bay Area, NYCWireless in New York City, or Personal Telco in Portland, Oregon. Many hook without permission into corporate networks or home broadband connections. An increasing number, however, are funded by governments, universities, and non-profits who see a benefit in providing widespread wireless Internet access. Athens, Georgia offers free WiFi connectivity throughout its downtown area, funded by the University of Georgia, while Intel sponsors free WiFi connections in Manhattan's Bryant Park. Hotspots and community access points have generated significant media attention, and for good reason. However, they are only one element of a WiFi market that includes several other major applications.